

How I Became a Ghost Ch. 24-26

By Tim Tingle





Chapter 24

A Soldier's Vow

IN SPITE OF THE FREEZING cold, Joseph fell asleep in minutes. His blanket was soon covered in snow. I knew he was exhausted from the long day of rescuing Naomi, setting fire to the soldiers' camp, rushing Naomi to the bonepickers' wagon, and catching a raccoon with his bare teeth!

I sat watching him sleep. I was neither tired nor cold.

Life is very different as a ghost, I told myself. I learned something else that night: Without sleep, life as a ghost can be boring!

That must be why ghosts know everything, I thought. *While everybody else is sleeping, they float around and see what's happening.*

I closed my eyes tight and imagined the soldiers' camp. When I opened them, I stood by the burning wagon. The soldiers had tried to put the fire out with buckets of snow, but the wagon was destroyed. Piles of smoking embers were all that remained.

Roundman leaned against a tree, wide-awake, with his shotgun over his lap. The other soldiers were asleep in their wagons. I searched the wagons till I found Leader. He was tossing and turning, adrift in a nightmare of the fire and Naomi's escape.

"I will kill you for this!" he called out in his sleep.

His anger was strong, and I knew he would seek revenge in the morning. I returned to my family's camp. Everyone was safe and sound asleep. Nita lay between her mother and father. She smiled and waved at me.

"Where have you been?" Jumper asked.

“Jumper,” I said, “I’ve missed you!”

“Yeah, life’s not the same without you, either.”

“Is everything *hoke*?” I asked.

“*Hoke* for now, but stay close in the morning. Trouble’s coming. That’s what everybody says.”

“Well, everybody is right. The soldiers will be looking for you, you know.”

“How’d you like my little act?” Jumper said with pride. “I jumped in the river and got their attention, so you and Joseph could save Naomi. That water was cold, but it was worth it.”

“You were great, Jumper! But this battle is not over quite yet,” I said. “Get some sleep, and I’ll see you in the morning.”

"Chi pisa lachike," Jumper said. When he saw the surprised look on my face, he added, "What? You never heard a dog speak Choctaw before?"

"Jumper, you have to be the smartest dog in the world!"

"Yakoke," said Jumper.

I waved good-bye as I floated away.

The light of day came slow and quiet that morning. No red streaks in the sky announced the sunrise. I circled the soldiers' camp till one by one they rolled out of bed and joined Leader by the campfire.

"Stay together today," Leader said. "We will find the girl. She and her family will pay. Feed the horses well and carry extra shotgun shells. If anyone runs, shoot them."

"Do you want anyone to guard the camp?" asked Pointy Nose.

"No!" shouted Leader. He grabbed his shotgun and walked slowly to Pointy Nose. "Ask me that again," he said, in a low and menacing voice.

"Do . . . you want anyone . . . to guard the camp?" Pointy Nose stammered.

Leader tilted his hat to the back of his head and looked to the sky. Every soldier stared at him, unsure of what he would do next. Leader took a step back, lifted his shotgun to his shoulder, and swung it hard at the skinny soldier.

Pointy Nose fell to the ground, with blood flowing from a cut on his forehead.

“Do you have your answer?” Leader shouted. “No guards! You are not getting out of this!”

Roundman leapt to his friend and wrapped a cloth around his head. Blood soaked through the cloth, and Roundman packed the wound with snow to stop the bleeding.

“Now,” said Leader, “saddle your horses and let’s go. We will search every wagon, starting with the Choctaw Council’s. Climb in the wagons and search in every corner. When you find the girl, bring her to me.”

As the soldiers mounted their horses and stepped to the icy road, Leader shouted, “Someone will die today.”



Chapter 25

A Day of Death

TWENTY SOLDIERS ON horseback rode behind Leader. As they approached the camp of the Choctaw Council, he held his hand high. The soldiers waited. Joseph crouched beside me, watching from the shadows.

“Shotguns!” Leader shouted. The soldiers lifted their guns to their shoulders.

“You are welcome in our camp,” said Mister Tibbi. He rose from the campfire and stepped to the soldiers, who held their guns ready to fire.

“Take aim!” shouted Leader. He pointed to the tree limbs hanging over the council members, men and women both.

“Let us talk about what happened last night,” said Mister Tibbi. Leader ignored the Choctaw councilman, as if he were nothing more than a patch of snow on the road.

“Fire!” shouted Leader.

Boom! Boom! Boom! Twenty shotguns exploded, shattering the treetops. Ice-covered branches fell all about the camp, destroying the fire circle and toppling the cooking pot. A large tree limb ripped through the roof of the wagon. Joseph quickly turned into the panther and growled with anger.

“Joseph, no,” I shouted. “The soldiers will shoot you. You can’t escape twenty men in daylight. Stop, please. Naomi needs you alive.”

The panther turned to look at me.

“After you burned the wagon last night,” I said, “they would love to parade your body for everyone to see. You don’t want that. Naomi could die, too.”

The panther paused at the mention of Naomi. His dark coat receded, and soon Joseph knelt beside me.

At first glance, the Choctaw council members appeared to be safe, but soon a low moan rose from beneath a heavy branch.

“Stella,” a woman shouted. “Help me, someone!”

Two councilmen rolled the limb away, and elderly Stella lay unconscious. A large purple bruise covered one cheek and her eye was swollen shut.

Mister Tibbi stood his ground.

“We did nothing to deserve this,” he said, in a quiet but strong voice. Leader leaned from his saddle and, for the first time, spoke to Mister Tibbi.

“You are lucky no one died,” he said. “But the day is not over yet. Find the girl and bring her to us.”

Mister Tibbi turned to his camp. Nani Humma dragged the tree limb from the wagon and the women circled fallen Stella.

“Let’s move!” shouted Leader. The soldiers tugged the reins and moved their horses down the road.

As Joseph and I watched, something changed among the uniformed horsemen, some new cloud of fear hung in the air. Since they had left their campsite, only a short while ago, they had become deeply afraid of Leader. They had stood and stared, helpless to stop him, as he struck Pointy Nose with his shotgun.

He might have killed him, they realized. Privately they wondered, *What might he do to me?*

But seeing how helpless the Choctaw council members had been, with no guns or weapons, the soldiers also felt a new power, the power of life and death. They reloaded their shotguns as they rode, eager for the day. By the time they reached the next camp, their fear had turned to anger.

“No walking!” Leader shouted at the next group of Choctaws, sitting quietly around their morning fire. “You,” he said, pointing to a young Choctaw man. “Run to the others and tell them to stay where they are. No walking today.”

He turned to his waiting soldiers. “Turn the camp inside out. Burn the blankets,” he said.

The soldiers leapt from their horses and invaded the camp. They tore blankets from women and children huddled from the cold. They threw the blankets into the fire. If a man stood in their way, they knocked him to the ground.

Word soon spread up and down the line of Choctaw walkers.

“The soldiers are coming!”

When the soldiers arrived at every camp, they found Choctaws standing away from the fires, clinging to their children. As they rode from the camps, flames lifted high from the burning blankets. Curls of smoke filled the air, as closer and closer the soldiers came to my family.

“Joseph, I have to warn them,” I said. “They’ll come after Naomi’s parents. I’m going.” In a moment I stood by the campfire where my two families gathered. I closed my eyes and came to life before their eyes.

“Are we safe?” my father asked.

“Yes,” I said. “Let them have your blankets and say nothing.”

“They are looking for Naomi, aren’t they?” Gabe asked.

“Yes, and they are angry,” I said. “They don’t know Nita is dead. They’ll be looking to take her.”

“What should we do?”

“Show them her body,” I said. “Unroll the blanket and let them see that she is dead.”

“I do not want the soldiers to cast their eyes on my little girl,” Ruth sobbed.

“They might take her body from us; they might try to burn it.”

“Mother,” said the tiny voice we had come to expect. Nita appeared. “I am here. I am with you. My body is not me. Whatever the soldiers do, let them do.”

“Nita is right,” I said. “When the sun sets on this day, we want everyone to be safe. If they scatter Nita’s bones, we will gather them. If they burn her bones, we will gather the ashes. We are Choctaws. We are stronger than the soldiers.”

I could not believe I had spoken those words.

For a long moment, everyone stared at me in silence. A warm yellow cloud rose from the fire and filled the air. Old Man appeared in the cloud. Soon he was joined by every Choctaw from our town, the living and the dead. Our tiny camp was filled with hundreds of people.

The living people looked confused, not knowing where they were or how they came to be here.

Finally, Old Man spoke.

“The young man is right,” he said, nodding to me. “Every Choctaw needs to hear his words.”

Though my lips didn't move, my voice filled the air, and I heard myself say once more, “When the sun sets on this day, we want everyone to be safe. If they scatter Nita's bones, we will gather them. If they burn her bones, we will gather the ashes.

“We are Choctaws. We are stronger than the soldiers.”



Chapter 26

Choctaw Rattlesnake

“THERE THEY ARE!” Leader shouted. “The girl’s family! They know where she is.” The soldiers circled the camp, staying on their horses.

“My daughter isn’t here,” said Gabe, stepping forward. “We do not know where she is. Search all you like, you will not find her here.”

“She can’t be far,” Leader said, turning to the soldiers. “If she tries to run, don’t shoot her. She needs to suffer for the trouble she’s caused.”

“What about you?” Leader said, pointing to my father. “Have you seen a girl with short hair, dressed like a boy?”

“I do not know where she is,” my father replied.

"Then I must believe you," said Leader. His voice was evil and his face was hard. "What reason would you have to lie? I guess you've heard by now, this girl has escaped. But we don't need to find her. We have a promise to keep."

He turned to Gabe. "Where is your other daughter, the little one?"

"She is no longer with us," Gabe said.

"You are lying!" Leader hissed. "Bring her to me now!"

I expected Ruth to cry, but she did not. Instead, she carried Nita's body, wrapped in the blanket, and laid it by the fire.

"Here is my daughter," she said, and unrolled the blanket. Nita looked so small and helpless. Her face was swollen and her eyes were shut tight.

The soldiers stepped back and looked away. I felt the warm shiver creep through my skin. I closed my eyes and hoped. I did not want to see how anyone would die, not today.

When I opened my eyes, I saw children hovering close to their fathers. Boys and girls clung to their soldier fathers. Many were the same age as Nita, whose body now lay before them.

The soldiers have children, I thought, and they are hoping this never happens to any of them. Thinking of their children, the soldiers hung their heads and waited for their orders.

“What would you like us to do?” Pointy Nose asked. I knew by his manner that he had no children. Nita’s death meant nothing to him. He was more concerned with winning back Leader’s trust.

“Well,” said Leader, “I am glad to see that one of us is not afraid of death. Roll her up and take her with us!”

“Be glad to,” Pointy Nose replied, with a thin smirk on his face. He stooped to Nita’s body.

I saw Gabe look at my father. My father nodded, so slightly the soldiers didn’t see.

They share a secret, I thought. What do they know?

Pointy Nose reached for the blanket, but something stopped him. His eyes grew large and a look of fear replaced the smirk. A soft sound filled the silence, a soft whirring sound. It grew louder and louder till the air around us shook with the sound.

Whirrrrr! Whirrrrr! Whirrrrr!

The head of a rattlesnake weaved back and forth over Nita’s body.

“Sir,” said Pointy Nose, “I can . . . not . . . please don’t make me do this.”

“Shut up!” Leader said. “Get back on your horse. We can’t waste our time here.”

He turned to Gabe and Ruth.

“You have lost one daughter already,” Leader said, “so I cannot keep my promise. But I made a vow this morning. Someone will die today. We will find the girl and she will die.”

As the soldiers rode away, the snake lowered his head and coiled into a tight circle. Ruth looked at Gabe and my father, then knelt to Nita’s body.

“*Yakoke*,” she whispered. She bowed her head over her daughter, and the snake disappeared in a thin cloud of curling smoke.

Only later would I learn who cast the spell and brought the snake. On this morning I simply bowed my head like everyone else and whispered my gratitude.

“*Yakoke*.”